Six North Sea Seabirds: A Student Learning Guide

Grohnpetrel learning resource · Team Guillemots, Constructor University Bremen · Version of 11 November 2026

About this guide. Grohnpetrel is a fictional academic project: a coastal-conservation and seabird-education concept created by the Guillemots, four students at Constructor University in Bremen-Grohn, for a digital marketing course. It is **not a registered NGO, charity or official university initiative, not a bird species, and it does not accept donations**. The birds and facts in this guide are real; every fact comes from the sources listed on our species pages. Online version: Seabirds of the North Sea.

How to use this guide

- Read the overview table, then one profile per bird. Each profile gives two observations and a link to the full page with its sources.
- Answer the learning questions on the last page, alone or in class. The glossary explains the key terms.
- Free to print and share for learning. Photos are credited under their own licences (CC BY-SA 4.0).

The six birds at a glance

Bird	Scientific name	Length	IUCN status	Why it matters
Northern gannet	*Morus bassanus*	87–100 cm	Least Concern	Largest of the six; breeds on Helgoland
Atlantic puffin	*Fratercula arctica*	28–30 cm	Vulnerable	Nests in burrows; numbers falling fast in Europe
Black-legged kittiwake	*Rissa tridactyla*	37–41 cm	Vulnerable	Cliff-nesting gull that depends on sandeels
Common tern	*Sterna hirundo*	31–35 cm	Least Concern	Beach nester that winters off Africa
Eurasian oystercatcher	*Haematopus ostralegus*	40–45 cm	Near Threatened	Mudflat shorebird with an orange bill
European storm petrel	*Hydrobates pelagicus*	14–18 cm	Least Concern	Tiny petrel; the bird group in the name Grohnpetrel

Bird profiles

Northern gannet *Morus bassanus*



Northern gannet in flight, Lummenfelsen, Helgoland. Photo: Carsten Steger, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons (resized). Source · Licence

Observation 1. One of the biggest seabirds of the North Atlantic, with wings up to 1.8 m across. Since 1991 it has bred again on Helgoland, Germany's only bird cliff.

Observation 2. Gannets hunt by plunge-diving: they fold their wings and hit the water at up to about 100 km/h, reach roughly 11 m by momentum, then swim deeper, on average to about 20 m.

Full page with all sources: https://business.constructor.university/guillemots/northern-gannet/

Atlantic puffin *Fratercula arctica*



Atlantic puffin with lesser sand eels. Photo: Charles J. Sharp, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons (resized). Source · Licence

Observation 1. A small seabird of the North Atlantic that nests in burrows on grassy cliff tops. It has been classed as Vulnerable since 2015 because its numbers are falling fast in Europe.

Observation 2. Puffins spend autumn and winter far out on the open ocean and only come to the coast in late spring to breed. Young birds stay at sea for two to three years before they return to land.

Full page with all sources: https://business.constructor.university/guillemots/atlantic-puffin/

Black-legged kittiwake *Rissa tridactyla*

Observation 1. A small, ocean-going gull that nests on narrow ledges of sheer sea cliffs, including Helgoland's bird cliff. Classed as Vulnerable since 2017.

Observation 2. The name comes from its call, a shrill "kitti-wa-ake". Some colonies have moved onto buildings: on the River Tyne in England, 1,639 pairs nested on buildings in 2020, 879 of them on the Tyne Bridge.

Full page with all sources: https://business.constructor.university/guillemots/black-legged-kittiwake/

Common tern *Sterna hirundo*

Observation 1. A slender, fork-tailed seabird that nests on beaches, dunes, salt marshes and islands, and spends the winter as far away as western and southern Africa.

Observation 2. Common terns catch small fish by plunge-diving from 1–6 m above the water. They breed in colonies, usually of fewer than 2,000 pairs, and also accept floating rafts built for them.

Full page with all sources: https://business.constructor.university/guillemots/common-tern/

Eurasian oystercatcher *Haematopus ostralegus*

Observation 1. A black-and-white shorebird with a long orange-red bill, common on European coasts and mudflats. Despite its name, oysters are not a big part of its diet. Classed as Near Threatened.

Observation 2. Oystercatchers usually pair for many years. Both parents incubate the eggs for 24–27 days, and the chicks leave the nest a day or two after hatching, still fed by their parents.

Full page with all sources: https://business.constructor.university/guillemots/eurasian-oystercatcher/

European storm petrel *Hydrobates pelagicus*

Observation 1. One of Europe’s smallest seabirds, just 14–18 cm long. It nests in crevices and burrows on remote islands and only visits its colony at night.

Observation 2. Storm petrels flutter low over the waves and pick food from the surface. They can find oily food by smell, and they often follow ships.

Full page with all sources: https://business.constructor.university/guillemots/european-storm-petrel/

Learning questions

1. Which two birds are classed as Vulnerable? Compare where each of them nests.
2. Gannets and common terns both plunge-dive. How do their dives differ in height and depth?
3. Kittiwakes on the River Tyne nest on buildings and a bridge. What does this suggest about how the species adapts?
4. The puffin's young stay at sea for two to three years. Why does this make the species slow to recover?
5. The word "petrel" is part of "Grohnpetrel". Which of the six birds is a petrel, and how small is it?
6. Choose one bird and write three sentences about it for a younger student, using only facts from this guide.

Mini glossary

Term	Meaning
Seabird	A bird that finds most of its food at sea, such as gannets, puffins, kittiwakes, terns and petrels.
Petrel	A seabird of the tube-nosed group (order Procellariiformes), which spends most of its life on the open sea.
Bird cliff	A steep rock face where seabirds breed close together on ledges. The Lummenfelsen on Helgoland is Germany's only bird cliff.
Colony	A place where many birds of one or several species breed close together.
Tidal flat	Sand or mud that the sea covers at high tide and uncovers at low tide; rich in worms and shellfish that many birds eat.
Bycatch	Animals caught unintentionally in fishing gear, for example seabirds diving after bait.
IUCN Red List	The global list that assesses how threatened species are, from "Least Concern" to "Extinct".

More terms: Seabird and Coast Glossary.

Sources

- https://birdlife.org/news/2021/07/06/seabird-month-northern-gannet-morus-bassanus
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Northern_gannet
- https://www.helgoland.de/en/thats-helgoland/nature/
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Atlantic_puffin
- https://birdlife.org/news/2021/10/06/seabird-of-the-month-black-legged-kittiwake-rissa-tridactyla
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Black-legged_kittiwake
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Common_tern
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Eurasian_oystercatcher
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/European_storm_petrel

Status classes follow the IUCN Red List as cited on each species page. Facts were checked on the species pages, which were written and sourced by the team between 2 and 8 November 2026.

About Grohnpetrel

Grohnpetrel is a fictional coastal-conservation and seabird-education project from Bremen-Grohn, Germany, created in 2026 by the Guillemots student team at Constructor University. It carries out no conservation work and takes no money. Website: https://business.constructor.university/guillemots/ · Definition: What is Grohnpetrel? · Archived with a DOI: doi:10.5281/zenodo.23926767.